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PS4 announcement ahoy!

Sony will finally reveal the PlayStation 4 early this month. Lets hope we see more than the controller this time

Monitors Test

HOW WE TESTED

We called for only LED backlit LCD monitors having full HD resolutions and were 21.5-inches and over and meant for home use. We did however receive a couple of 3D gaming monitors and three professional grade monitors. Since there weren't enough numbers, we decided to divide the monitors based on their screen sizes. Professional monitors were grouped together as they are more feature rich as compared to other monitors and are meant for imaging professionals. Since a majority of the monitors were meant for home use, we thought it would not be fair to mix the two categories.

As far as features went, we logged all the physical specifications on the monitors including details of the panel, connectivity options, swiveling options, USB ports, etc. Build Quality was evaluated and scored accordingly. We also evaluated the on-screen display options and its ease of use.

Our test bed comprised of the following components:

- Processor: Intel Core i5-2500K
- Motherboard: ASRock Z68 Extreme4
- RAM: Kingston 8 GB DDR3 RAM @ 1333MHz
- SSD: Kingmax 128 SSD
- Graphics Card: NVIDIA GTX 460 (with the NVIDIA 3D Vision 2 kit for 3D monitors)

Before testing any monitor, we reset it to its factory settings to ensure uniformity. We used Spyder 3 Elite colorimeter to calibrate each display and also to give us the real contrast ratio and luminance value. Manufacturer's specified contrast ratios are determined under certain conditions and at specific brightness and contrast levels. While the luminance is calculated at 100 percent brightness, we noticed that it was not the correct level for calculating Contrast ratio, as some monitors showed heavy back-light bleeding on maximum brightness. So to calculate contrast ratio with the Spyder 3 Elite colorimeter, we calculated Contrast ratios with brightness levels at 100 percent and 50 percent and contrast fixed at 75, as most use cases will have the brightness within this limit. All monitors were tested on Standard Mode with User Colour feature activated for us to be able to tweak each of the RGB sliders. All enhancement options were disabled.

The calibrated monitors (at 50 percent brightness level) were then subjected to Lagom.nl tests which basically involves checking the black and white gradients where you check for smooth transition from black to white levels and also look for any colour tinging. This was followed by the black level test (on a black background)

and white level (on a white background) where you check the monitor's ability to separate the different shades of black and white against a pure black and pure white backgrounds. Pixel walk (inversion) consists of varying moire patterns occupying the screen (there are as many as 11 variations), and you look at the flicker control of the monitor.

We then moved on to movie quality testing. We used three full HD movies such as Avataar, Skyfall and The Human Centipede. In each movie we looked at around 5 or 6 specific scenes. We evaluated the monitor's ability to control noise or dithering, its contrast levels, detailing in certain scenes, control of ghosting in fast action scenes, resistance to backlight bleeding, looking at colour renditions, skin-tones and so on. These data points were then averaged out for each movie.

Viewing angles were also evaluated for text, movie and game display. PixPerAn was used to evaluate how well the monitor could enable readability of scrolling text.

After finishing the above tests, we again set the monitor to its factory settings. Since most monitors come with preset modes, we decided to check the contrast ratios in the most commonly used presets such as movie/theatre mode and multimedia/photo mode.

of the monitor. The NEC E231W is targetted more towards business users, so a lot of stress is laid on the two Eco modes – one corresponding to Energy Star settings and the other to 40 per cent energy savings. It makes sense for larger organisations who want to increase their green

quotient. Features such as auto-brightness and auto-contrast where the monitor dynamically adjusts both helps further. You can also adjust the LED brightness levels. It has four colour settings whose RGB sliders can be adjusted along with a Native and sRGB option where you

cannot tweak the RGB settings. BenQ GW2250 is the only VA panel sporting monitor in this category. Navigating the OSD using the buttons is very easy and it also has options to manipulate the RGB sliders but only in the Standard picture mode. The ASUS VS238H has a com-

paratively better design than the BenQ GW2250. We quite liked the non-recessed ports and the circular base of the monitor will ensure that the DVI or D-Sub cable connecting the the VS238H has enough breathing space. It has the preset modes which it calls Splendid modes,



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